

SAMPLE SYLLABUS: GENDER AND POLITICS IN EAST ASIA

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Course Objectives

The primary objective of this course is to immerse students in the issues related to gender and politics in East Asia from both a gender studies and political economic perspective. The first part of this course will discuss major theoretical approaches to studying sex and gender in political science, including constructivist, structural, and intersectional frameworks. The second part of the course centers on different substantive themes relevant to gender topics in the East Asian region, such as gender and work, gender socialization, low marriage/fertility rates and gendered migration/care work. The primary objective of this course is to provide students with a theoretical understanding of gender politics and a deep understanding of main empirical questions of the subfield pertaining to East Asia.

Course Format

This is a discussion-based undergraduate seminar.

Course Structure and Assignments

Participation and preparation for each class, as well as the final research paper are important for this seminar. The assignments and work requirements for the students are as follows:

(1) Class participation

10%

- Attend every session having all the assigned readings digested. You must be ready to fully engage in the class discussion.
- The first half of the class will be instructor-led, consisting of lecture modules focusing on key theoretical conceptions with built-in discussion activities. The second half of the class will consist of student-led discussions of substantive material (see #3).
- Repeated tardies or absence without legitimate excuse will negatively affect this grade.

(2) Midterm exam

30%

- Students will write an in-class exam based on the first half of the course, which covers an introduction to gender theory. Prior to the midterm, a list of theoretical concepts (“key terms”) will be given to students to review.
- The exam will consist of two short essay questions that ask students to present and synthesize the main arguments of the theoretical concepts, cite the relevant authors, and put them into conversation with each other.

- The exam will be conducted in-class, either handwritten or on a lockdown software. If accommodations are needed, please contact me with relevant details from the Office of Student Accessibility Services.

(3) Discussion leadership 15%

- Each student is assigned to lead discussions one time during the second half of the semester. Depending on class size, students might be paired up. Discussion leaders will start the class discussion by presenting relevant topics and questions for the first 20 to 30 minute of class.
- Discussion leaders are to look up certain technical terms and provide an explanation of the key theoretical concepts or arguments to be discussed, synthesizing the reading material for the week.

(4) Group project 15%

- Students will form groups of 3-4 and pick one gender issue relevant to East Asia or a broader Asian context. The topic should be one that is not directly addressed in the course.
- Students will present about the topic in class (not exceeding 10 minutes) using the theoretical concepts from the first half of the course to explain the phenomenon. Outside research on the topic is expected and encouraged, and a works cited list is required.
- In lieu of a traditional presentation, students can also choose to film a video (i.e. a skit, an informative PSA, a documentary/mockumentary style) in vertical/horizontal format to show to the class. The video must not exceed 10 minutes.
- Half of the group project grade is the instructor's assessment, and the other half will be based on anonymized student evaluations of group members at the end of the project to encourage equitable divisions of labor.

(5) Final Research paper 30%

- Students can choose a question/topic that further explores an issue addressed in the course, a completely new one, or one that is inspired by the group projects as long as it is relevant to the course substantively/theoretically. The paper must be about 20 double-spaced pages (approximately 5,000 words, no more than 6,000). Any paper that does not follow these rules will be penalized, unless the instructor specifically gives you written permission.
- A paper proposal is due on (DATE, TIME). This proposal must include a research question, a working argument, theories/concepts that are relevant to this question, and a list of at least 10 scholarly sources that pertain to the topic. This proposal will not be graded but will receive extensive feedback from the instructor, and the degree to which the student incorporates the feedback into the final paper will be accounted for in the final grade.
- Students MUST schedule at least one office hour session before (DATE, TIME) to talk about their proposal with the instructor. Office hours after that can be scheduled at any time, but any paper submitted without any office hours will be subject to grade deductions.

Course Schedule (based on a semester schedule, meeting twice a week)

The readings are presented in a strongly suggested reading order.

Class Meeting 1 Explanations of the course goals and syllabus

Class Meeting 2 Introduction to Gender as a Category

Mills, J. S. (1869). The Sameness Approach. In *The Subjection of Women* (pp. 97–112).

Connell, R. W. (1987). *Gender and Power*. Stanford University Press. Pages 183-188.

Scott, J. W. (1988). “Gender: A Useful Category of Historical Analysis.” Pages 28-50 and 206-211 in *Gender and the Politics of History*. New York: Columbia University Press.

Class Meeting 3 and 4 Introduction to Gender as a Category: Applications

Friedan, B. (1963). *The Feminine Mystique*. Pages 15-32.

West, C., & Zimmerman, D. H. (1987). Doing Gender. *Gender & Society*, 1(2), 125-151.

Butler, J. (1990). Preface, 1990. In *Gender Trouble* (pp. xxvii–xxxiii). Routledge.

Class Meeting 5 and 6 Radical Feminisms

Mackinnon, C. (1989). Sexuality, Pornography, and Method: ‘Pleasure Under Patriarchy’. *Ethics*, 99(2), 314–346.

Rich, A. (1980). Compulsory Heterosexuality and Lesbian Experience. *Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society*, 5(4), 631–660.

Mackinnon, C. (2019, March 24). Where #MeToo Came From, and Where It’s Going. The Atlantic.

Class Meeting 7 and 8 Marxist Feminisms

Engels, F. (1884). *The Origin of the Family, Private Property, and the State*. Pages 734-59.

Hartmann, H. (1979). The Unhappy Marriage of Marxism and Feminism: Towards a More Progressive Union. *Capital & Class*, 3(2), 1–33.

Class Meeting 9 Intersectionality

Crenshaw, Kimberlé. (1989). Demarginalizing the Intersection of Race and Sex: A Black Feminist Critique of Antidiscrimination Doctrine, Feminist Theory and Antiracist Politics. *University of Chicago Legal Forum*, 1989(8).

The Combahee River Collective. (1977). A Black Feminist Statement.

Class Meeting 10 Global/Cross-cultural Feminisms

Mohanty, C. T. (1991). Introduction: Cartographies of Struggle. In C. T. Mohanty, L. Torres, & A. Russo (Eds.), *Third World Women and the Politics of Feminism* (pp. 1–47). Indiana University Press.

Mies, M. (1986). Introduction. In *Patriarchy and Accumulation on A World Scale* (pp. 1–5).

Class Meeting 11 Examining Masculinities

Connell, R. W. (1987). Femininity and Masculinity: Sexual Character. In *Gender and Power* (pp. 183–188). Stanford University Press.

Connell, R. W., & Messerschmidt, J. W. (2005). Hegemonic masculinity: Rethinking the concept. *Gender & Society*, 19(6), 829–859.

Cohn, C. (1993). Wars, Wimps, and Women: Talking Gender and Thinking War. In M. G. Cooke & A. Woollacott (Eds.), *Gendering War Talk*. Princeton University Press.

Class Meeting 12 MIDTERM REVIEW

Class Meeting 13 MIDTERM

Class Meeting 14 Special Module: Forming a good research question

Optional reading:

Gustafsson, K., & Hagstrom, L. (2023). The insecurity of doing research and the ‘so what question’ in political science: How to develop more compelling research problems by facing anxiety. *European Political Science*, 15.

Class Meeting 15 Gender and Work: East Asian Context

Daminger, A. (2019). The cognitive dimension of household labor. *American Sociological Review*, 84(4), 609–633.

Chuang, H.-L. and Lee, H.-y. (2003). The Return to Women's Human Capital and the Role of Male Attitudes Toward Working Wives: Gender Roles, Work Interruption, and Women's Earnings in Taiwan. *American Journal of Economics and Sociology*, 62: 435-459.

Oh, E., & Mun, E. (2022). Compensatory work devotion: How a culture of overwork shapes women's parental leave in South Korea. *Gender & Society*, 36(4), 552–577.

Class Meeting 16 Group Project Set-up and Brainstorm Time

NOTE: Research Paper Proposal DUE

Class Meeting 17 and 18 The Politics of Marriage and Fertility in East Asia

Brinton, M. C., & Lee, D.-J. (2016). Gender-role ideology, labor market institutions, and post-industrial fertility. *Population and Development Review*, 42 (3), 405–433.

Raymo, J. M., Park, H., Xie, Y., & Yeung, W. J. (2015). Marriage and Family in East Asia: Continuity and Change. In *Annual Review of Sociology* (Vol. 41, Issue Volume 41, 2015, pp. 471–492).

Brinton, M. C., & Oh, E. (2019). Babies, Work, or Both? Highly Educated Women's Employment and Fertility in East Asia. *American Journal of Sociology*, 125(1), 105–140.

Uchikoshi, F., Mugiya, R., Yoda, S., & Raymo, J. M. (2026). Revisiting the Relationship between Marriage and Childbearing in East Asia: The Role of Fertility Desires in Japan. *Population and Development Review*.

Class Meeting 19 and 20 Gendered Migration in East Asia

Cheng, C. M. C., & Choo, H. Y. (2015). Women's Migration for Domestic Work and Cross-Border Marriage in East and Southeast Asia: Reproducing Domesticity, Contesting Citizenship. *Sociology Compass*, 9(8), 654–667.

Islam, M. R., & Cojocar, S. (2016). Migrant Domestic Workers in Asia: Transnational Variations and Policy Concerns. *International Migration*, 54(1), 48–63.

So, C. (2006). Asian Mail-Order Brides, the Threat of Global Capitalism, and the Rescue of the U.S. Nation-State. *Feminist Studies*, 32(2), 395–419.

Abrahamson, P. (2016). End of an Era? China's One-Child Policy and its Unintended Consequences. *Asian Soc Work Pol Rev*, 10: 326-338.

Class Meeting 21 (Anti-)Gender Attitudinal Formation in East Asia

Yang, W.-Y. (2016). Differences in gender-role attitudes between China and Taiwan. *Asian Women*, 32(4), 73–95.

Go, M. H. (2025). Does Gender Equality Matter for Democracy? Confucian Norms and Public Attitudes Toward Democracy in East Asia. *Journal of Women, Politics & Policy*, 46(4), 339–360.

Kweon, Y., Kang, W. C., & You, J. (2025). Revisiting Candidate Gender Effects: Heuristics, Sexism, and Information Environments. *Politics & Gender*, 1–22. Cambridge Core.

Class Meeting 22 Constructions of Masculinity in East Asia

Hudson, V. M., & Den Boer, A. (2002). A Surplus of Men, A Deficit of Peace: Security and Sex Ratios in Asia's Largest States. *International Security*, 26(4), 5–38.

Jenkins, M. D., & Kim, H. J. (2024). The Role of Misogyny in the 2022 Korean Presidential Election: Understanding the Backlash against Feminism in Industrialized Democracies. *Journal of East Asian Studies*, 24(2), 169–196.

Gongning Ma, Chunduoer Yang, Zhaojun Qin, & Meixi Guo. (2021). Hegemonic Masculinity in East Asia: China, South Korea and Japan. *Proceedings of the 2021 4th International Conference on Humanities Education and Social Sciences (ICHESS 2021)*, 2405–2410.

Class Meeting 23 and 24 Legacies of War: Militarized Sexual Labor in East Asia

Enloe, C. (2014). Base Women. In *Bananas, Beaches and Bases: Making Feminist Sense of International Politics* (2nd ed., pp. 125–173). University of California Press.

Moon, K. H. S. (1999). South Korean Movements against Militarized Sexual Labor. *Asian Survey*, 39(2), 310–327.

Du, C. (2022). Jeep Girls and American GIs: Gendered Nationalism in Post–World War II

China. *Journal of Asian Studies*, 81(2), 341–363.

Class Meeting 25 and 26 Group Project Presentations

Class Meeting 27 In lieu of class: Extra office hours for final research paper